

you're looking to validate during the trial period and how we can help you (demo, docs technical support etc).

Cheers,

Hi [prospect],

Thank you for your interest in GitLab Enterprise Edition.

In case you did not receive the email with the license file yet, I have attached it to this email.

Do you have any questions or issues regarding GitLab so far?

It would be great to understand what the problems and tasks are, that you are trying to solve with GitLab Enterprise Edition?

Looking forward hearing from you.

Best regards,

6 Ways to Make Your Sales Email Insanely Valuable to Prospects {insanely}

The "just checking in" sales email isn't just ineffective -- it's also selfish.

Reps who send these types of emails aren't offering any value. They're trying to force or persuade buyers into replying to their message and making a purchase on the rep's preferred timeline.

However, in today's sales world, providing value to a customer throughout their individual buying process is the only way for a rep to close a deal. Hard selling tactics are bad for the buyer, and bad for the rep.

Modern reps are committed to providing guidance, information, and value to buyers whenever they reach out. They know it's important the prospect sees just as much return on their time as the rep does.

Here are six easy ideas as to how you can provide value with each sales email you send.

1. Attach a piece of content

The easiest way to provide value to a buyer in a sales email is to include a piece of helpful content. Remember: The goal of an initial sales email is to not try to convert a buyer into a customer instantly, but to give them something that will truly interest them, and get a conversation going.

Spend some time researching the prospect's company and observing their behavior on social media. Use this knowledge to offer a piece of content specific enough to their interests that they take the time to read it.

Email subject: a resource for you...

Hey [prospect],

Saw you sent out a tweet about [subject] and thought I'd pass along this blog post. It talks a lot about that subject, and provides some interesting takes and opinions. I would love to hear what you think about it.

All the best,

2. Reference a mutual connection

Having a mutual connection in common with a buyer can go a long way. In fact, a prospect is five times more likely to engage with a seller when they share a connection.

Surfacing a common connection is valuable to the buyer because it fosters trust. The buyer can now check with that mutual connection and determine whether or not this is the right product or service for them.

Email subject: I see we both know Leslie.

Hey [prospect],

I know you've been doing your research on GitLab, so I thought I'd put you in touch with someone we both know. [Mutual connection] and I have known each other for a while and they have been using GitLab, and it turns out you know each other too.

Maybe all three of us can get together some time. Talk to you soon.

All the best,

3. Offer a customer review

Simply put, customers love reviews. How often do you check out Yelp before you make a decision on where to eat? How deep in the reviews do you go? I know I scan for a while, and I'm willing to bet you do too.

Learning what other people are saying about a product or service plays an important role in buying decisions. In fact, 88% of people take online reviews as seriously as they do personal recommendations, according to a study from Bright Local.

It's clear that reviews are valuable for prospects, so why not send one along in your next email?

Email subject: the people have spoken

Hey [prospect],

I spent the weekend surfing the web, and came across some pretty cool reviews about what we've been talking about. I know you've been trying to solve [pain point] so I'm sending you these

links to help you gather some more info.

Link 1

Link 2

Link 3

In these reviews, customers go into depth about how the product works and what they think of it. They're honest, real, and I think you'll appreciate them.

If you have any other questions, let me know. Talk to you soon.

4. Send over a case study

A case study can add instant value to a sales email. If the prospect is in a difficult spot and unsure how to proceed, sharing a story about a customer in a similar situation that describes how they solved their problem can be incredibly helpful.

Email subject: I've seen this story before

Hey [prospect],

It's funny, but after talking with you this last week I remembered that one of our customers was actually in the same situation you are in now. They were cruising along and crushing their market, but they were having problems with [pain point].

I attached their story to this email. It's an interesting take, and I think it will provide a wealth of insight into how exactly they became one of the leaders in their market. Would love your feedback on it.

All the best,

5. Provide a tactical suggestion

If you notice an area of weakness in the buyer's business that you think you can help improve, let the prospect know. Offering insights not only strengthens your relationship, but it builds your credibility in their eyes.

Email subject: have you tried doing this?

Hey [prospect],

I was on your website earlier, and noticed a new blog post. I was wondering if you have ever tried out [suggestion]. It's a really simple way to help blog posts rank better in search. It can also boost social shares, and help you build out your brand.

Here are a few examples of blog posts that use this technique:

Example 1

Example 2

Example 3

If you're not sure what I mean, just give me a shout. Great post, by the way. I just shared it. Let's connect soon.

All the best,

6. Just respond

Simply responding to a question, voicemail, tweet, or email is the easiest way of all to provide value. And keep in mind that you don't have to give the final answer right away. A simple "I'm looking into this for you" will assure the prospect that you're on the case.

The value of responding quickly extends beyond solving specific problems. According to Sprout Social, 26% of customers who don't hear back from a company take to social media to post negative comments. Remember the importance of good reviews? Responding quickly plays a major role in prospects' perception of your business.

Email subject: thanks for the question!

Hey [prospect],

Thanks for getting in touch. That's a great question, and I'm glad you asked. I'm in the middle of a few meetings this morning, but I've sent your question along to our support experts (cc'd on this email). They'll be able to help, and I'll follow up with you at the end of the day.

Thanks again! If anything else comes up, please let me know.

All the best,

As author Michael Port recently wrote, "Give away so much value that you think you've given too much -- and then give more."

Sales reps need to understand that the modern buyer is busy and doesn't have time for "just checking in" emails. Strive to offer buyers an instant ROI with each and every message you send.

Every word you say during a sales process is important. Every conversation you have is an opportunity to drive the process forward or derail it. With this in mind, it's crucial to make sure these conversations count.

3 Seemingly Scary Words Reps Shouldn't Be Afraid to Use

How often have you experienced an awkward silence during a sales call because the prospect asked a question you weren't exactly sure how to respond to? If you've been in this position, don't worry -- this happens on sales calls more than you think.

The common reaction for most sales reps is to get back to the parts of the service or product they are most knowledgeable about and move the conversation forward. But what about the question the prospect asked? If you just forget about it and keep talking about the benefits of your product, they'll decide to buy eventually -- right?

Probably not.

So if ignoring the question and hoping it goes away doesn't work, what does? What should you do when the prospect poses a question you don't quite know how to answer?

Say three short words:

"I don't understand."

While some reps might be afraid to say these words and reveal a chink in their "trusted advisor" armor, let me make the case for why this is the best option when you're truly stumped.

"I don't understand" allows you to clarify

Understanding exactly what your prospect is saying allows you to avoid deal-disrupting miscommunications down the road. With this opening, the prospect can explain the question further so you can gather as much information as possible before responding.

"I don't understand" provides an opportunity to follow up

In the event you get stumped with a prospect, saying you don't know but will pursue the information with someone who does creates a perfect opportunity to follow up after the call is over. You can add value to your follow up by providing the requested information, while impressing the prospect with your diligence and commitment.

"I don't understand" allows you to gain new knowledge

From now on you'll know how to properly inform prospects seeking similar information. A knowledgeable sales rep is a trustworthy sales rep, and any opportunity you have to gain information is one you want to take advantage of.

"I don't understand" helps you become more likable

Recent studies suggest that being honest makes you more likable. Instead of feeling like you don't know what you're talking about, a prospect will likely be impressed with a sales rep who admits that they don't understand something. This proves your honesty and your willingness to be up front.

"I don't understand" enables you to ask better questions

Instead of just moving on to the next part of the call, use "I don't understand" to gather more information about your prospect and gain insight on how to refine your questions. Asking the right questions can help prospects paint a clear picture of their business, their plan, and their pain. With additional information, you can adjust your strategy to fit exactly what the buyer is looking for.

"I don't understand" prompts them to use their own words

Instead of trying to rephrase the prospect's question for them, prompting them with "I don't understand" gives the prospect the freedom to explain their situation and pain point in their

own words. The rep can now get insight into how this prospect views their pain points, which is incredibly valuable when trying to tailor a solution and sell value.

Saying "I don't understand" on a sales call isn't the end of the world. Sales reps can strategically use this phrase to uncover a prospect's meaning and give a genuine response. Remember, the prospect isn't going to have all the answers. It's okay if you don't either. Put the focus on the relationship and providing value, and you'll be okay.

Understand?

6 Questions Sales Reps Should (But Don't) Ask Themselves Before Sending an Email

Few things top getting off on the right foot with a prospect. When you and the buyer connect off the bat, making the sale just comes naturally.

And where does that first impression happen? More often than not, online, with the first email you send. So here are a few things to ask yourself before you reach out to prospects for the first time to ensure your message will make a great first impression.

1. Do I know their pain point?

A prospect's pain is the primary reason they are going to make a purchase. Before writing that crucial first email, you need to understand how your product can help turn their pain point into a strength. If you don't understand their pain point, or at least have a general idea of what they're likely struggling with, it makes positioning your product as a solution difficult. Without knowing what it is they need to solve, how can you help them solve it?

To determine pain, commit to research. Study their business and look for a weakness or a point where they could improve.

2. Do I know what's happening in their market?

Studying a prospect's market gives you insight into their biggest challenges and where they need to improve. If you notice that some companies are hiring and expanding while others are cutting back, you have a clear picture of which companies are trending in the right direction.

By demonstrating knowledge of the prospect's market in your initial email, you can build credibility with this person. You're not only knowledgeable about their business, but you've taken the time to study their competitors and can now help implement an effective strategy for change.

3. Will my name be familiar?

With an average response rate of 1.7%, the cold email is clearly losing its effectiveness.

Why? It lacks context. Today, we all screen our calls and emails. If we're unfamiliar with the person reaching out to us, we'll probably ignore them.

If the prospect doesn't recognize your name, their initial reaction might be to hit the "report

spam" button on your email. In sales, this a less-than-ideal outcome.

So instead of this person seeing your name for the first time in their inbox, aim to become familiar online first. To create rapport with a person before the first email, connect with them on social media, comment on a blog post they've written, or reach out to a mutual connection and ask for an introduction. All three of these techniques give you a chance to spark a discussion and make your name familiar.

4. Do I have the right mindset?

Approaching a sale with the mindset of helping, guiding, and offering clarification is the mindset of the modern rep. According to CEB, today's buyer is going through almost two-thirds of the journey without talking to anyone in sales. With this in mind, reps need to adjust and be ready to embrace the "always be helping" mentality, instead of "always be closing."

This takes the stigma of an annoying, pesky, or pushy sales rep out of the equation because you're looking to guide prospects through their buying journey. If write your email thinking you have to close, you might shove your product down their throat or force them through the funnel faster than they want to go.

5. What's the value of this email?

What does the prospect get out of your message? What insights can you offer them in this email that they can't get somewhere else?

Keep in mind that any touch can be the deciding factor behind whether or not this person buys from you. Bothering a prospect with an email they don't need can be the downfall of a rep -- before the sale ever begins. When you're able to offer value from the jump, you prompt responses and move the conversation forward.

Here are a few things you can include to make your email valuable:

- Offer a strategy suggestion
- Reference a mutual connection
- Include a blog post about your product
- Send a customer review

6. What action do I want the recipient to take?

What's the goal of this email? Do you want the prospect to reach out when they need more information or are you looking to set up a product demonstration?

Reps can often forget to include a call-to-action in their emails, making it difficult for the prospect to respond. Without giving prospects a defined next step, it can be a challenge to move forward.

Here are some examples of calls-to-action reps can include in their sales emails:

1. Include a calendar invite
1. Provide a case study and ask the buyer to read it

1. Ask when they're free for a discussion
1. Send them to a piece of content for review
1. Ask a question about something they've written

The introductory email sets the tone for the relationship. Before you reach out, ask yourself these six questions to determine whether or not you're fully prepared to send that email. If you can't answer all of these questions, hit the reset button and get back to the drawing board.

Bill Cates from Hubspot {art}

Wrote a great article about "The Art of Asking Open-Ended Questions." Here are some highlights

High-value questions bring value to the conversation and creates a learning experience for you and your prospect/client.

High-value questions are open-ended instead of closed-ended.

If your question can be answered with a simple "yes" or "no", that is a closed-ended question. Questions that begin with "Did", "Are", "Would" and "Is" are closed-ended.

To turn a closed-ended question to an open-ended question, start with "How", "If", "What", "Why", "Who". The result of an open-ended question is you gather more insight from the prospect/client and they become more involved in the process as well.

Here are some open-ended, high-value questions that reps can ask their prospects:

- What are the top priorities in your business at the moment?
- What are some of the best decisions you've made related to ?
- How are you feeling about your current situation related to ?
- If we were meeting five (10, 20) years from today, what must happen for you to feel good about your situation related to ?
- What opportunities do you see on your horizon?
- What challenges do you see in making this happen?
- If we were to work together on this, what are the top two or three outcomes you'd like to see?
- How will you be measuring our success related to these outcomes?
- What's the biggest risk for you to not make progress on this situation?

4 Ways to Ruin a Sales Presentation

A perfect sales presentation paints the product, the company, and the rep in an ideal light, while captivating the audience and turning a target company into a customer on the spot.

However, while a great meeting with a prospect can set you apart from your competitors, a bad presentation can do the same thing. Sales reps can often fall into the traps of a bad presentation without even realizing it. Everything is going smoothly in the rep's mind ... until they realize the CEO has fallen asleep.

So how does a rep avoid this scenario? Below are four avoidable sales presentation mistakes to

keep in mind for your next meeting.

1. Being overly general

Not personalizing the presentation is a mistake because every buyer is different. Each buyer has a unique pain point, and is in need of a unique solution. By failing to customize the presentation, the buyer can't see themselves using your product. All the buyer knows is that the product works in general, or a different business used it and had success.

When we tell stories, the people listening feel as if what's happening to the protagonist is happening to them too, according to studies. By personalizing the message, a sales rep can put the potential buyer into the shoes of another customer who has experienced success using the product, and help them visualize how the offering could help their company as well.

2. Listing too many benefits

Speaking about too many benefits can turn a prospect off because our brains can only process so much information at once. In fact, recent studies have found that consuming too much information can distract a person, resulting in a negative impact on personal well-being and decision making, among other things.

Instead of bragging about everything your product can do, sales reps should focus on three to four benefits that will solve a very specific pain point for the prospect. Studies have found that humans retain information best when they find it useful. By highlighting a few key, relevant benefits in your presentation, the prospect is more likely to retain the information, which will be critical when they make a decision.

3. Slipping into autopilot

Beginning a presentation with a monotone voice, bad body language, or an obviously scripted intro can kill your momentum in a hurry. According to Sherrie Bourg Carter, emotions are contagious. So if a sales rep lacks energy and enthusiasm during their presentation, this lackluster mood will likely wear off on the stakeholders in attendance.

There are a multitude of ways to avoid autopilot. By giving the presentation beforehand to coworkers, reps can discover where they need to improve and where the information could be strengthened. Another trick is to have a cup of coffee or work out the morning before the presentation to raise your energy. If you're full of energy and enthusiastic about your product, these feelings can spread to your audience.

4. Dodging questions

Dodging questions after a sales presentation is a bad idea because it doesn't allow the audience to clarify information, and according to 24Slides, can weaken your credibility. When prospects aren't able to have specific questions answered, they can't learn about what matters most to them. Instead of leaving the presentation feeling great about the product, the prospect is likely to leave with more questions than answers, which defeats the whole purpose of the presentation.

While reps might have a fear of answering questions after a presentation, it's important to

open the floor to the audience. Reps who take the extra time to answer tough questions can showcase what it's like to work with them on an ongoing basis and the commitment they have to their prospects and customers. And remember, if you're truly unsure, there's nothing wrong with saying "I don't understand" and moving forward.

A sales presentation can be tricky to master. Reps can give 1,000 of them but still have an off day every once in awhile. By focusing on reversing some bad habits, reps can ensure their prospects enjoy their presentations and find it valuable.

Persistent or Just Plain Pushy? 7 Sales Behaviors Decoded

When was the last time you called a prospect and they said, "I'm so glad you called! I love salespeople!"?

Probably never.

Salespeople: Are You Being Persistent or Pushy?

Salespeople face a unique dilemma. On one hand, tenacity is key to getting business -- 80% of sales requires five follow-ups to close.

On the other, coming off as annoying is a real concern. Salespeople have a negative perception to overcome, and many buyers assume the worst.

In sales, the line between pushiness and persistence can be hard to walk. Here is a list of pushy behaviors to avoid -- and what to do instead.

PROSPECTING

- Pushy: Cold calling without doing research and delivering a cookie-cutter pitch
- Persistent: Following up on an inbound lead with an introduction customized to the prospect's activity and context.

CONNECTING

- Pushy: Pitching immediately without providing context on who you are and why you're calling
- Persistent: Providing a reason for your call (ideally the prospect's previous activity or a referral) and offering to help.

NURTURING

- Pushy: Sending "just checking in" emails without providing new value
- Persistent: Providing your prospect with a strategically sequenced progression of new, helpful resources and insights

DISCOVERY

- Pushy: Rushing through a long list of discovery questions so you can "cover all your bases."
- Persistent: Diving deep into areas your prospect is interested in, letting conversation flow naturally toward their priorities, and following up with more discovery calls if necessary.

DEMONSTRATION

- Pushy: Attempting to cover every feature of your product at once.
- Persistent: Focusing your presentation only on features and benefits relevant to your prospect's needs.

OBJECTION HANDLING

- Pushy: Glossing over your prospect's concerns and not taking them seriously.
- Persistent: Creating a plan that accommodates your prospect's objections, and actively addresses their hesitations.

CLOSING

- Pushy: Trying to "slam a deal" through on your timeline and your terms.
- Persistent: Making sure your prospect's on track to achieve their goals and is ready to implement your product upon purchase.

Recognize that there's a fine line between being annoying and tenacious. The same sales activities can be executed in very different ways -- some good, some bad.

A Two-Step Formula for Handling Pricing Objections

Below is a proven two-step formula that can help you handle any pricing (or any other) objection, for those times when your ounce of prevention may not be 100% foolproof.

Step 1: Count to three

Whenever you're faced with a difficult question or objection, the first thing you need to do is take a deep breath, make eye contact with your prospect and silently count to three.

It is amazing how many clients will answer their own objections, or at least give you some much-needed information, when you simply say nothing. Don't be afraid of silence. Practice it until the three-second pause becomes one of the most effective tools in your arsenal.

A couple of years ago, I was buying a new pair of glasses and having lenses put in an old pair. The optician was clearly afraid to talk about price, and even went so far as to write the estimate down on a piece of paper and pass it to me instead of saying the price out loud.

To my surprise, the number actually struck me as very reasonable. I had left my purse at home, so I turned to my husband to get his wallet. The optician took my silence as an objection and immediately dropped the price 15%.

This seemingly minor transaction was a great demonstration of the power of silence, and the lengths most people will go to in order to fill it. In sales, you can use silence to effectively handle almost any objection, particularly those related to price.

Whenever a client tells you your price is too high, just breathe and be quiet. You will find that around 40% of all prospects will fill that silence with information you can use to move the sale forward.

Step 2: Ask questions

Step 2 is to ask questions. You can ask up to three questions before you have to answer an objection · provided you ask the right questions in the right way.

The key is to acknowledge what the customer is saying and then offer them a compliment before asking your question. For example, try saying something like "I appreciate you asking that," "that's a really great question," "I understand how you feel" or "good point, I never thought about that!"

Including a nice warm statement in front of your question will encourage your customer to answer it, because they will feel like you are giving them something first. The compliment is a gift. It makes them feel that they are special, that you are paying attention to them and that you truly care about them, and they will be more likely to respond in kind.

Which questions to ask?

Once you've paid the client a compliment, ask them a question that is both direct and phrased to elicit more information. The following are some responses you can use to answer a few of the more common objections.

OBJECTION: "Your price is too high!"

RESPONSES: "Your price is too high!"

- Thanks for sharing that. How much too high are we?
- I appreciate your telling me that. Have you found a less expensive product?
- You are right, we are more expensive than some of our competitors. How much were you hoping to pay?
- You're right, we are not the cheapest. Is price the only consideration? · Thanks for being honest. Is the price higher than you expected, or is it because we combined the services and training in one proposal?
- I'm not surprised to hear you say that. Are we only too high overall or is our per-unit cost too high as well?
- Thanks for sharing that. Is our price a showstopper?
- I appreciate your honesty. Does our current price mean we will never be able to do business together?
- Too high? Really?
- What do you suggest we do?
- Thanks for letting me know. I'm curious, how much were you expecting to invest?

OBJECTION: We don't have any budget

RESPONSES: We don't have any budget

- Budget?
- Oh! I appreciate that makes it difficult to buy. When does your budget come up for renewal or review?
- Thanks for letting me know. Is your budget renewed annually or quarterly?
- Does not having a budget mean we will never get a chance to do business together this year?

OBJECTION: I need a discount

RESPONSES: I need a discount

- Discount?
- It's good of you to be looking for the best deal. How much of a discount do you need? Why that much?
- Making sure you're getting the best deal for your company is a good idea. If we can't budge on the price, does that mean it's over between us?

Echo! Echo

Another option for asking questions is to use the ECHO technique.

The echo technique is simply the art of taking the last word (or last important word) in a client's sentence and turning it into a question.

Whenever a client says "I need a discount," look them squarely in the eye and say "discount?" Ninety-nine times out of a hundred, the customer either tells the rep exactly what they need to do from a price and terms point of view to move the deal forward, or offers alternatives to the pricing model that will make both parties happy.

What could be simpler than that!

Price Objections - The Script that Always Closes

You hear it all the time · if your price is higher than your competition you're told to "build value." You're instructed to stress the quality, the warranty, the features, etc. But your prospects have heard all that before, haven't they? Want a better way?

Let's face it · prospects will often buy from people they like, know, or trust. Your enthusiasm for your product or service is also a big factor in getting your prospects to place an order with you as well. Knowing this, I've often used the following script to not only build value in my product or service, but also to build value in myself. Here's what to say:

If your prospects says, "I can get cheaper," or "Well the XYZ company has something similar or for less money," or anything like that, say:

"You know I'm aware of all the other options for this Git Repository Management and quite frankly if I thought any of them were better for my clients, I'd be working there and selling them.

"When I got into this industry I did my own research, and I looked for the best company that not only offered the best product but also delivered the best customer service and follow-up. I chose GitLab because they give my clients the best overall value and the best experience and that means they continue to do business with me and refer new business to me as well.

"If there was a better product or company for you to be doing business with I'd be there and we'd be talking about that. But there isn't.

"Bottom line · if you want the best overall value, results, and experience, then do what I do did · choose GitLab · You'll always be glad you did. Now, do you want to start with the X size order or would the Y size order be better?"

This technique builds value in the most important part of any sales transaction · you and your belief in your product or service. Use it each time you get the price/competition objection and watch your sales and confidence growth.

Mixed Tier Objections - Refocus on the value and deployment

Scenario: Customer really likes Ultimate but feels that only 1,000 of the 4,500 developers really need it. They ask to buy 1,000 seats of Ultimate and 3,500 seats of Premium and to have it all work together as one.

Translation: I don't understand why Ultimate is so valuable that it's a no-brainer to buy it for all of my users.

Solutions:

- Refocus the conversation on the business outcomes and value of those outcomes. The customer already pays more than the price of Ultimate for a collection of tools that do not deliver the outcomes they want. This is an opportunity to pay less and get the outcomes they want.
- Is the customer worried that only part of the team is cloud native? That's okay! Ultimate is for all developers and approaches and makes it easy to support legacy and cloud-native approaches at the same time. The DevOps value applies to all of their developers.
- We don't support multiple types of users on one deployment because it would make a bad experience. We also don't split the servers for the same reason. Our job is to make the customer successful and splitting the deployment is not the path to success.
- Listen to the customer when this question is asked. They either understand the value but are still asking for a discount in the form of mixed tiers or they don't understand the value at all.
- If they are really talking about price, dig into the details (deployment timing, sequence, services needed) to ensure we've optimized every possible angle for the customer.
- Work with the customer to use more stages of GitLab in their deployment. They will see improved business outcomes and results. This validates the price.
- Leverage the CS team! A customer considering Ultimate should have hands-on experiences to see the massive benefit they get from the product.
- Is the customer uncomfortable because they are used to paying for security products for only a few users to operate? Refocus on the value. In many cases they may \$250,000 for a product operated by 5 people to drive security outcomes. With GitLab, they may pay a higher tier price for every user to ensure better security outcomes end-to-end, but the total cost of the increase is actually much less than the products they use today and provides better business

outcomes! Focus on the value because price per user is misleading if you are not focused on overall value to the customer.

5 B2B Sales Call Techniques That Get More Meetings

If there's anything I've learned from listening to thousands of sales calls, it's this: despite all the tools intended to help sales reps engage with prospects -- email, lead and account scoring, content, social media alerts, and many more -- calls are still where relationships are forged or lost forever.

To put it simply, every other sales activity is leading up to one thing: a phone call. Not surprisingly, reps that have the best phone skills are almost always the most successful. In my experience, here are the five sales call techniques that the best reps put into practice with every prospect.

1. Show Maximum Respect

Many of your calls are no doubt scheduled in advance, but some aren't. Near the beginning of unscheduled calls, ask this one simple question: "Have I caught you at a bad time?" You'll be surprised how few people say yes. That's because by simply asking the question, you're conveying that you're a thoughtful and respectful human being.

2. Justify the Call

Before even dialing, imagine your prospect asking you, "Why are you calling me?" (with the emphasis on the word "me"). If you can answer that question eloquently and convincingly, then you're bound to add value during the call.

For example, "I'm calling because we're in the same beekeeping LinkedIn group, and I noticed you asked whether any group members could recommend a good supplier." Or, with a repeat customer, "You've ordered four cedar hives from us in the past, so I thought you'd want to know that we released a brilliant new model."

3. Verify the Role

One of the keys to B2B sales is reaching out directly to the person whose job/career/life your product will improve. As a sales rep, you'll do research to ensure that you're calling the right person. But because people change roles all the time, you should verify this up front as well, even if you've talked to the person in the past.

For example, "Just to make sure, you're still involved in managing beekeeping operations -- do I have that right?" You'll be surprised how often people will respond with something like, "Actually, I changed roles, but I'd be happy to intro you to the person who's doing it now."

4. Personalize

For best results, use public information to find common ground that helps you to connect as a person. For example, "I noticed that we're both connected to Jack White. Great guy, and an incredible guitarist. How'd you meet?"

Alternatively, you can reference prior engagement. For example, "I saw that you downloaded our bee relocation cheat sheet, and I wondered if our mobile cedar hives might be a good investment for you."

5. Verify Compatibility

As is often the case in B2B sales, you may have a technology, size, or geography requirement. You're obviously going to research compatibility ahead of the call, but you also need to verify it before you waste anyone's time. For example, "Just so you know, our new hive frames are only compatible with WBC hives. Would that be an issue for you?"

If there's one common thread in all these tips, it's that the most successful sales reps put their customers' needs first. Add value, be honest and respectful, and offer information -- not a sales pitch. If you can put all of these sales call techniques into use, you'll be crushing your meeting quota in no time.

Dan Tyre wrote

a great article about "How to Create a Sales Plan" [a name="buyingplan">](#). Here are some highlights

First, I would like to change our thinking from being a sales plan to a buying plan. This puts us in the mindset of the buyer and helps us use words focused on them and not us. The purpose of a buying plan is to help the process move forward. To avoid inertia. Time kills deals so we putting a plan in place that moves the conversation and process forward is essential.

To determine if you need a buying plan at all or how comprehensive it should be, you first need to understand the sophistication of your buyer. A good question to ask is: "Have you bought a similar product before?"

This question is crucial. If this is the first time they've ever bought something like your offering, your plan needs to outline how to buy in the first place. You'll need to walk them through how to get internal buy-in and how to evaluate if your product is a good solution, working closely with them throughout.

Your Buying Plan needs to have Goal-Related Questions

1. What are your goals?

- People who don't have goals don't make good customers. Your job is to find great prospects who will also make great customers.

2. What's your why?

- Prospects don't buy for rational reasons -- they buy for emotional reasons. Your product is a rational means to an end, but that end is usually influenced by emotion. Your prospect has an image of the future in their head, and your product is what can help them get there. Getting a prospect talking about that future helps them understand why they should invest time and money in your solution.

3. What changes will result from this plan?

- This is an impact question. What is the impact of them using this product successfully?

What fundamental changes will need to be made to their business?

4. If you don't know the answers to these questions, do you know who to ask to find out?
 - This is crucial as it brings in additional "champions" to the discussion.

Your Buying Plan needs to have Process-Related Questions

1. Who's responsible for buy-in?

- Knowing who will be impacted by using the product, where the budget will come from as well as impacted by the change in moving to GitLab is essential.
- It is also just as important to identify and bring into the conversation any stakeholder who is or acted as a champion for a competitor. Find that person and get them on your side.

1. What are your biggest challenges to the purchase?

- Identify the roadblocks to purchase as soon as possible. This question will help you understand what still needs to be done.

1. What happens if you don't complete this purchase?

- Find out your prospect's Plan B. It could be that they're totally screwed if they don't make this purchase, and asking them to envision that possibility will kickstart the sales process. It could also reveal that you're in a competitive situation, in which case it's time to reach out to a coach or champion and figure out where you stand.

1. What's your personal goal?

- Know whether my prospect has skin in the game. This informs you of the motivating levers you can pull to move the deal ahead and forces the prospect to revisit exactly why this deal is important to them. The closer you get to the end of a sales cycle, the higher the chance that your prospect will be fatigued. Refocusing them on the prize is crucial.

Now that you have created the Buying Plan, what to do after

1. Ask the prospect to review it. Formally present it if you need to and ask how you can help them get buy-in.

2. Get buy-in from stakeholders on the plan so that everyone is on the same page.

3. Answer the naysayers. Go straight to your blockers with the plan to air out all their objections.

4. Define the purchasing process by asking questions like the ones below.

- Who needs to be involved in the actual purchase -- signing contracts, approving budgets, etc.?
- Does the purchase require an RFI (request for information), an RFQ (request for quotation), or any other documentation you'll be responsible for coordinating?
- Does Legal need to get involved?
- If additional documentation or reviews are needed, how long will those processes take?

73 Insightful "How" Sales Questions That Get Buyers Talking

Art Sobczak wrote a great article on 73 Insightful "How" Sales Questions That Get Buyers

Talking

These HOW questions are broken down into categories

1. Fact-Gathering and Qualifying Questions
1. Need Identification Questions
1. Closing Questions
1. Addressing Resistance and Objections
1. Customer Service Questions
1. Questions to Ask Yourself

25 Phrases That Signal a Prospect Is Ready to Buy

Aja Frost wrote an insightful article on 25 Phrases That Signal a Prospect Is Ready to Buy

As Aja points out, salespeople get happy ears and interpret the buyers response and interest as something not true and inaccurate. The key is to understand is your buyer in the consideration phase or the buying phase. This article calls out buying phrases that are committal. Which phrases are you hearing? Vague, abstract, no-committal. If so, then your buyer is in the consideration stage and not buying. Or is your buyer asking you or making very specific references to their interest in purchasing?

Quiz: Which phrase is a signal that the prospect is ready to buy?

1. "That seems like it could be helpful." or
1. "This tool would help us do X faster."

Answer is "This tool would help us do X faster.". Read the article to gain more insight and to help you translate what the customer is really asking and to tame our happy ears.

11 Sales Negotiation Mistakes You Might Be Making

Leslie Ye wrote an article on 11 Sales Negotiation Mistakes You Might Be Making

Even the best negotiators fall victim to one of these mistakes from time to time. Here is a list of the 11 mistakes with point 4, 5, and 10 resonating with me.

1. Treating negotiation as a zero-sum game
2. Not knowing why the prospect would buy
3. Not knowing why the prospect wouldn't buy
4. Negotiating too early
5. Negotiating with the wrong person
6. Treating all objections the same
7. Thinking price as the only lever you can pull
8. Giving something away without getting something in return
9. Not knowing when to walk away
10. You don't understand the prospect's decision criteria
11. You take things personally

How to Qualify an Account From Afar

1. Target accounts have at least one of the following:

- The company's core business model relies on software. Using Salesforce Navigator these companies are in the gaming, internet, ecommerce and software industries.
- At least 20% of the company's staff are software developers or other types of DevOps practitioners. Use Salesforce Navigator's advanced features to see this.
- Companies with more than 100 software developers. Use Salesforce Navigator's advanced features to see this.

2. Great target accounts have all three of the aforementioned characteristics or at least one of the aforementioned characteristics and at least one of the following:

- The company's headcount growth has been greater than 10%. This is best seen in the Insights tab of the company's LinkedIn page.
- The company is hiring DevOps practitioners. This is best seen in the jobs tab of the company's LinkedIn page.
- The company's technology stack lends itself to what GitLab has to offer.

3. The best target accounts have at least 3 bullet points from the first two buckets, with at least one bullet point in the second bucket along with one of the following:

- The company has targets with LinkedIn profiles that show an interest in the GitLab value proposition.
- The company published something in its blog or social media that indicates a need for the GitLab value proposition.
- The company has a number of internal users of GitLab core or free plans; this can be seen via <https://version.gitlab.com>.

SECTION: sales/training/customer-success-skills-exchange.md

The Technical Skills Exchange (previously known as Customer Success Skills Exchange) is a bi-weekly webinar focused on topics for the technical field team members. While this series is primarily planned with our Customer Success and SA organizations in mind, any and all field team members are welcome to attend.

- Each training session has a speaker and a moderator
- Sessions are approximately 50 minutes long

Upcoming Training

To see what training is coming soon, view the Technical Skills Exchange Issue Board.

Get an invite to the weekly session

To get a calendar invite to the Technical Skills Exchange, make sure you are added to the sales-cs email group

You can fill out an access request to request access to the email group. These groups are invited to the meeting so that each individual person does not need an invite.

Training Playlist

There are a few places to see previous Technical Skills Exchange Sessions:

- Technical Skills Exchange Highspot Page
- Technical Skills Exchange Youtube playlist on GitLab Unfiltered YouTube
- Technical Skills Exchange Q&A Doc

To request new Technical Skills Exchange session

- Comment on the current quarter planning issue which you can find on the Technical Skills Exchange Issue Board to connect with our team

Speaker Responsibilities

- Come prepared at least 2 mins before session is scheduled to begin to make sure you are ready to begin on time.
- Send your slides to the Customer Success and SA Enablement Program Manager and add them to the notes document
- Include any other relevant links to the notes document

Moderator Responsibilities

Overall Technical Skills Exchange Management

As the moderator for the Technical Skills Exchange, you are responsible for identifying topics, speakers, and dates for the quarter.

Webinar Moderator Responsibilities

Prior to Webinar

- One week before the webinar, confirm with the speaker that they are prepared and available for the session. This can help eliminate the need for last minute cancellations.
- Day before webinar, send an announcement in the customer-success, tim-tams, and solutions-architects Slack Channels.

During the Webinar

The moderator for each webinar should serve as the host of the call and overall wingperson for the presenter. The moderator monitors chat to raise questions to the presenter and searches for links that are mentioned on the call to make sure they get linked in the handbook page for the training.

- Log in to zoom 5 minutes ahead of time
- The video should not be recording, but pause if this is the case
- Promptly welcome everyone to the call and remind them that the call will be recorded. Specifically mention how to talk about sensitive info on every intro. Be sure to start the meeting as close to the start time as possible.
- Record the call.
- Monitor the time.

After the Webinar

- After the session, upload the recording to the Technical Skills Exchange Highspot.
- Post a announcement in the customer-success, tim-tams, and solutions-architects Slack channels, and link to the Highspot page.

Sample Announcement:

- > If you missed yesterday's Technical Skills Exchange session with <Presenter> discussing < Summary of session>, the recording is now live on Highspot!
- >
- > You can find links to all previously recorded sessions on the Highspot page and see the team Q&A in the session notes document.

SECTION: sales/training/field-functional-competencies.md

Field Functional Competencies

What are Field Functional Competencies?

GitLab field functional competencies provide a common language and consistent expectations for "what good looks like" for the GitLab field organization (inclusive of Sales and Customer Success roles). They are intended to complement GitLab's values and are comprised of specific behaviors that GitLab team members in a field role need to demonstrate consistently to be successful. These critical field skills and behaviors are not meant to be role or job-specific (as each role or job may have additional unique requirements), and how each competency is expressed or demonstrated may vary by role (e.g. by technical depth, engagement in different stages of the customer journey, team-specific expectations, etc.).

More specifically, functional competencies help to:

- Guide the growth and development opportunities available for GitLab field team members
- Build organizational capabilities when adopted and practiced across the field organization
- Reinforce behavior that is consistent with GitLab's values and culture
- Enable GitLab field team members to build productive relationships and generate positive results

There are three primary competencies for the field organization: Customer Focus, Solution Focus, and Operational Excellence. Please refer to the tables below to learn more or download and print the GitLab Field Functional Competencies one pager.

Customer Focus

Field team members should be focused on the customer and delivering a world class experience with every interaction.

EXAMPLE SKILLS / BEHAVIORS DESCRIPTION
---- -----

| Understanding the Customer's Needs | Leverages active listening to create mutual understanding between GitLab Team and customer regarding their short-term and long-term business challenges. Keeps the customer and their goals in mind when engaging with them. Seeks to understand their Positive Business Outcomes and how they define and measure success. |

| Customer Business Acumen | Understands the dynamics, trends, and challenges of the customer's business and their industry then appropriately advocates internally for the needs of the customer. |

| Effective Communication | Shares knowledge with customers in a way that creates credibility, demonstrates integrity, and conveys GitLab values. Adjusts presentations and delivery based on audience level and interests/needs. Communicates crisply and concisely (whether in person or remotely) and can capture and engage audiences with effective storytelling. |

| Facilitating (Customer Presence) | Projects confidence, credibility, and conviction in body language, voice, and words during meetings to show interest, gain respect, and inspire trust. Drives effective bi-directional dialogue that lead to productive outcomes for the customer and for GitLab. |

Solution Focus

Field team members should be focused on how GitLab helps customers solve their business problems and accelerate their success.

| EXAMPLE SKILLS / BEHAVIORS | DESCRIPTION |

| --- | ---- |

| Consultative Approach | Uses Command of the Message and MEDDPIC to effectively explore and diagnose customer needs and recommend appropriate value-based solutions to help customers achieve their strategic business goals. |

| Leading with Vision | Develops, documents, and executes effective strategies to land new customers with vision and purposefully expand existing customers adoption of GitLab technologies to accelerate customers' time to value and return on investment as they progress in their DevOps adoption journey. |

| DevOps and Technical Leadership | Demonstrates a comprehensive understanding of how products and services integrate to form solutions in the context of the customer's ecosystem. Advises customers on the importance of aligning people, process, and technology to achieve desired outcomes via an Agile DevOps methodology. |

| Building Trust (Trusted Advisor) | Connects with key stakeholders on both a personal and professional level and shows up as a credible and reliable champion for customers. Effectively positions GitLab as a partner to the customer rather than just another vendor with a focus on following through on commitments and delivering results. |

Operational Excellence

To drive efficiency, field team members should leverage the tools and processes established by Field Operations and their leadership.

| EXAMPLE SKILLS / BEHAVIORS | DESCRIPTION |

| --- | ---- |

| Process Discipline | Leverages repeatable and scalable processes and tools throughout the customer lifecycle. Effectively manages time, priorities, and daily workload to effectively engage customers. |

| Growth Mindset | Demonstrates the curiosity, perseverance, and willingness to take calculated

risks to continuously pursue opportunities to improve knowledge, skills, processes, and more that lead to improved results. |

| Account Planning & Management | Creates and implements effective long-term account expansion strategies by leveraging standard processes, tools, and content (including customer use cases and sales plays) |

| Resource Orchestration | Engages partners and internal resources and leverages tools at the right time and in the right manner to move the customer forward while prioritizing time and resources. |

Proficiency Levels

Competency proficiency rating levels align with GitLab's enterprise-wide performance categories:

- Developing
- Performing
- Exceeding

Practical Application

Field team members and their managers are encouraged to have regular coaching and development conversations to assess individual and team strengths and areas of opportunity across all competencies and the supporting/example skills and behaviors. More specifically, managers in the field organization should:

1. Encourage team members to conduct their own self-assessment to
 - Identify 2 or more strengths field team members intend to continue to leverage to deliver positive results
 - Identify 2 specific skills / behaviors field team members would like to improve upon
1. Complete a similar assessment for each of their direct reports
1. Next, meet with team members to compare and discuss assessment results then collaboratively brainstorm opportunities and agree on specific plans to support the team member's professional development and ongoing improvement

Field team members are also encouraged to identify and regularly engage with an accountability partner to maintain focus on development plans and provide ongoing feedback.

Self-Assessment

On an annual basis, the Field Enablement team will launch a self-assessment for field team members with CultureAmp. This information will help the Field Enablement team prioritize training needs and assess the efficacy of training programs throughout the year. This will not be used for performance reviews. For field team members and/or managers who would like to lead their own assessment exercises, please feel free to make a copy of the GitLab Field Competencies doc (see Assessment Template on the 2nd tab).

SECTION: sales/training/product-certification.md

Overview

As part of the Field Certification Program, the objective of this program is to ensure field team members have the requisite knowledge to serve as trusted advisors to customers, prospects, and partners by properly positioning the right GitLab solution(s) based on customers' or prospects' expressed needs and/or challenges.

Note: This GitLab product training and certification program is different from resources like the ones below that focus on how to use GitLab (though we encourage field team members to take these as well)!

- GitLab Certifications
- GitLab Technical Certifications

Architecture and Approach

1. Field team members are first trained on the DevOps Technology Landscape during Sales & Customer Success Onboarding
1. New field team members are then trained on customer value drivers and GitLab's value-based messaging framework (also during onboarding)
1. After onboarding, field team members will be encouraged to complete lightweight role-based product training learning paths (see below)
1. Field team members will then be encouraged to complete customer use case courses that focus on how to sell GitLab

mermaid

graph TD;

A[DevOps Technology Landscape]-->B[Customer Value Drivers & Messaging Framework];

B-->C[Foundational Product Knowledge];

C-->D[Selling to Customer Use Cases];

What the Field Needs to Know

Product training and certification learning objectives are defined for customer use cases based on what and how key GitLab features and capabilities deliver against prioritized market requirements for each customer use case.

Learning objectives are also defined for what the field needs to know about GitLab's product tiers. Two sets of prioritized product learning objectives are maintained--one for Sales roles and one for Customer Success roles.

Training

Lightweight role-based product training learning paths (one for Sales roles and one for Customer Success roles) are being developed to support the learning objectives outlined above with the goal of launching by or before early FY22. Until that time, team members and partners are encouraged to leverage and consume existing Handbook resources and participate in existing informal continuing education programs. New field team members will be encouraged to complete this training during their first few months in the role after successfully completing the Sales

Quick Start field onboarding training program as outlined above.

Certification

New team members will earn their GitLab product certification after completing the above learning path and scoring 80% or higher on the appropriate role-based product knowledge assessment.

Because GitLab launches a new release every month, role-based product knowledge learning objectives, assessments, and learning paths will be refreshed on a regular cadence (every six months) by the Use Case Activation, Product Marketing, and Field Enablement teams. Likewise, field team members must be recertified every six months (in early Q1 and again in early Q3). To be recertified, field team members must score 80% or higher on the appropriate role-based product knowledge assessment. If a team member scores less than 80%, they must complete the appropriate role-based product training learning path and will then have a chance to retake the knowledge assessment until they score 80% or higher. GitLab partner certifications will leverage the same training and assessment content (details TBD).

Current product knowledge assessments:

- Q3FY21 GitLab Product Knowledge Assessment for Sales roles
- Q3FY21 GitLab Product Knowledge Assessment for SAs and CSMs

SECTION: sales/training/social-selling.md

Social Selling Basics

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 <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/lr7od3stk70" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

LinkedIn Sales Navigator

- To gain access to LinkedIn Sales Navigator, request access through the Lumos App Store. Once access is approved, follow the Lumos-provided instructions to link your personal LinkedIn account to LISN.
- Sales Navigator Quick Start Guide (short 3-5 minute videos for a quick primer on how to get the most out of Sales Navigator)
- Sales Navigator Customer Hub: Resources
- Live and On-Demand Training Webinars
- Social Selling Index (SSI)
- LinkedIn Learning courses:
 - Social Selling with LinkedIn (Mar 2020)
 - Learning LinkedIn Sales Navigator (Dec 2020)

SECTION: sales/training/technical-questions-for-sales.md

Introduction

To improve sales efficiency and reduce the dependence of GitLab sales team members on Solution Architects (SAs), the SA team identified and answered the most common technical questions they believe GitLab sales team members should be able to answer. The following questions have been organized by DevOps lifecycle stage.

Manage

What authentication options are available when using .com?

- Short answer: SCIM, SSO, and OAuth
- Context video (4 minutes, May 2020):

<figure class="videocontainer">
 <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/8o1lfdte6Ps" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

- Learn more: Check out the System for Cross-domain Identity Management (SCIM) documentation

What options do we have to manage user access on .com?

- Short answer: In the Members section of a group, a group owner can invite existing or new users to a group. A group owner can also enable or disable the ability for non-members to request access to a group. SCIM can be configured, so users can be added as guests to a group or groups automatically.
- Context video (10.5 minutes, May 2020):

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 <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/cq85NMeOYY" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

- Learn more: Check out the SAML SSO for GitLab.com groups documentation

How should customers set up and customize user roles in GitLab?

- Short answer: GitLab manages access control through a combination of group-level and project-level visibility settings and user access levels for members. Groups and projects have three levels of visibility and users have five levels of access.
- Context video (5 minutes, May 2020):

<figure class="videocontainer">
 <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/N1YmkdvN2Bc" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

- Learn more: There are multiple types of permissions across GitLab, and when implementing anything that deals with permissions, all of them should be considered. Check out the GitLab permissions guide.

How can users be auto-provisioned?

- Short answer: Use LDAP integration
- Context video (5.5 minutes, May 2020):

```
<figure class="videocontainer">  
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/2UvAKN3WzY" frameborder="0"  
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>  
</figure>
```

- Learn more: Review the Create users through integrations documentation

How is user management different on .com compared to self-managed?

- Short answer: Since self-managed admins have complete ownership of the environment, they have more flexibility and configuration control. There are three buckets of primary differences:

1. Instance-level controls that just aren't possible on a shared server
1. Directory integration options, and
1. A few authentication options that are missing from GitLab.com (e.g. Kerberos and smartcard auth)

- Context video (3 minutes, May 2020):

```
<figure class="videocontainer">  
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/x1b2iqKOfI" frameborder="0"  
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>  
</figure>
```

- Learn more: Administrators have more powerful user management capabilities. Check out all the differences between GitLab.com and self-managed.

Manage Quiz

- Please take a moment to answer the questions in this short quiz based on the above videos and handbook resources for the top technical questions on the Manage stage.

Plan

What best practices exist around using projects/groups?

- Short answer: Groups are used to organize projects, control permissions to them, and aggregate data across them.
- Context video (5.5 minutes, May 2020):

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<iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/sgXoGdpMbd0" frameborder="0" allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

- Learn more:

- Review the No Tissues with Issues page
- Watch this How to set up GitLab groups and projects to run multiple Agile teams with microservices video (Jan 2019, 15 minutes)

How can we integrate Jira?

- Short answer: GitLab is a complete DevOps platform, delivered as a single application for everything from project planning and source code management to CI/CD, monitoring, and security. GitLab issues is a powerful tool for idea management, iteration planning, issue tracking and software development. However, we recognize that many organizations have been using Jira for many years and have existing data and business processes built into it. For some of these customers, this means it can be difficult and cost-prohibitive to move off of Jira. Core to our beliefs is that people (and tools) work better when they're all in one place, so to serve these customers, we are building an excellent integration that makes GitLab work wonderfully alongside Jira. If and when customers are ready to migrate to GitLab issues, we also provide the tools and practices to help with that.
- Context video (5 minutes, May 2020):

<figure class="videocontainer">
<iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/et3umKvcrX4" frameborder="0" allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>

- Learn more: Check out the GitLab Jira Integration page

What is the difference between the Jira integration in Free and in Premium?

- Short answer: GitLab Premium and GitLab Ultimate provides more robust options for integration points, integration links, integration set up, sync frequency, and user authentication.
- Update: The end of the video discusses the Jira Development Panel as a differentiator. The Jira Development Panel integration has since moved to Core as of 13.4.
- Context video (5 minutes, M